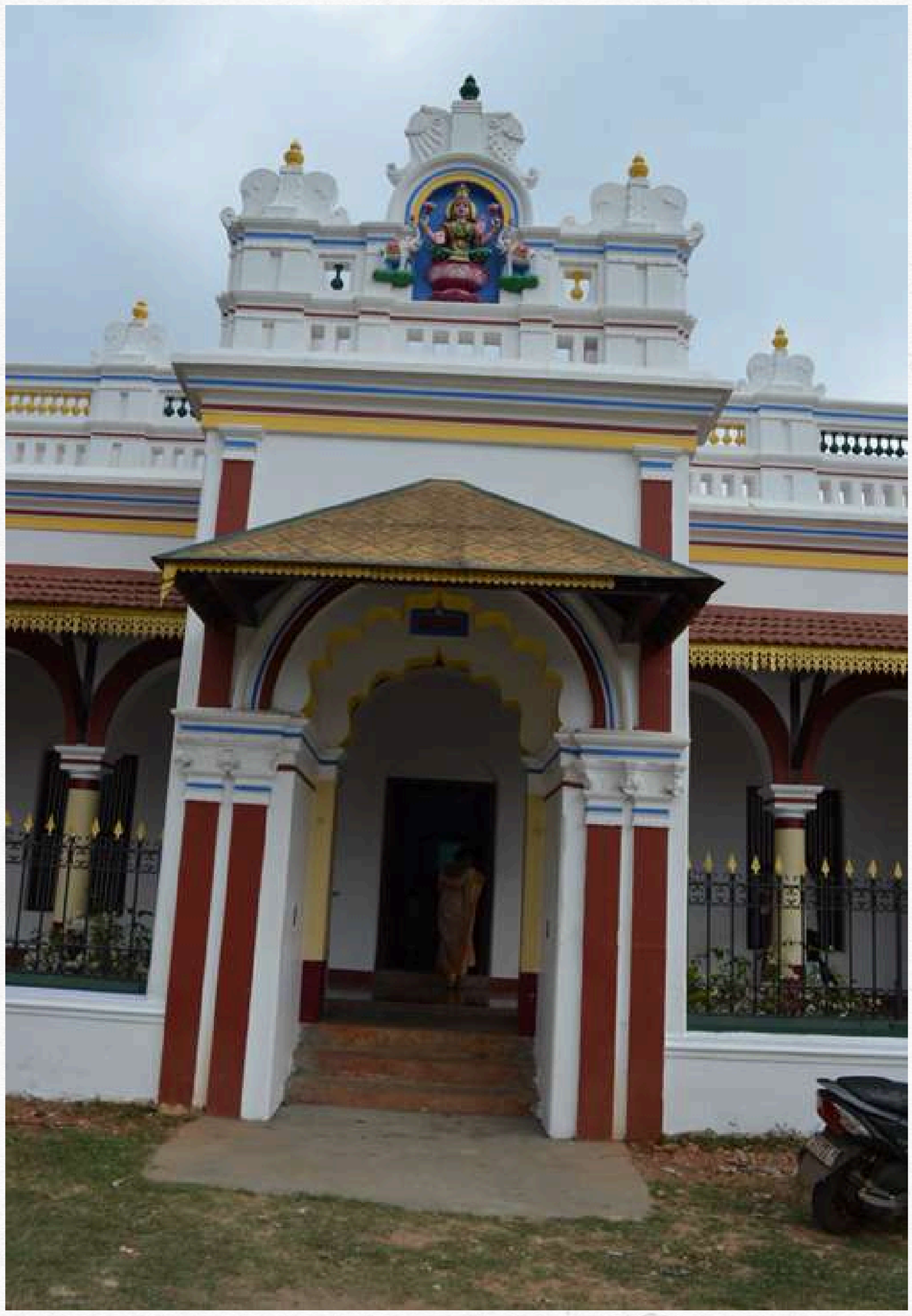
Happenings in Handmade

A CCI initiative

April 2026

SYMPOSIUM ON THE FUTURE OF THE HANDMADE SECTOR



Feb 1, 2026, Chettinad, Tamil Nadu
Theme: Craft, Climate, Technology, and Gen Z Entrepreneurship



Setting the Context

The resurgence of crafts after 2025 is being powered by technology and changing markets. Crafts are increasingly blending heritage skills with e-commerce and digital platforms, pointing toward a future of sustainably produced, tech-enabled, globally marketed, and eco conscious products.


THE
CRAFTS COUNCIL
OF
INDIA

Panel 1: Education, Gen Z, and Artisan Entrepreneurship





There’s growing urgency to build **entrepreneurial education** for Gen Z within craft ecosystems — combining traditional knowledge with digital tools and innovation. Programs like Creative Dignity’s Creative Enterprises Lab emphasise capacity building, digital skills, business practices, and long-term mentorship. Artisan entrepreneurs shared how training in photography, storytelling, and social media quickly boosted orders and brand visibility. The key takeaway: **the future lies in nurturing artisan entrepreneurs**—not just job workers—through education, technology, and better market access.





Panel 2: Craft, Technology, and the Future of Handmade Ecosystems





The conversation centred on how **digital platforms, collaboration, and transparency** can help strengthen the sector and address long-standing structural gaps.

Craft-focused e-commerce platforms such as iTokri demonstrate how digital marketplaces can connect artisan communities to wider audiences while creating meaningful economic opportunities and visibility for handmade products.

A collaborative “**guardian framework**” was proposed to build a transparent, trust-based system that enables identification, authentication, and stronger connections among stakeholders across the craft ecosystem.

The discussion emphasized how localized production systems, artisanal building traditions, and natural materials can contribute to more sustainable futures.


handmade world
A public-good digital networking platform created for India's handmade ecosystem.
What is Handmade.World ?
Handmade.World is a digital networking platform where users create and manage their own profiles, discover each other and collaborate.
Representing India's Handmade ecosystem, on your own terms
What Handmade.World does ?
Profile based visibility
Create & Manage profile
Ecosystem Discovery
Search by craft, region, material, & product type
Direct Connection
Reach out without any middlemen
Shared Knowledge & Opportunities
Access events & resources
Who is Handmade.World for?
Maker & Artisan Groups
Artisans, Collectives, NGOs, Co-operatives
Designers & Buyers
Retailers, E-commerce, Design led enterprise,
Service Providers
Content & Media, Export, Finance, Logistics, Legal
Why This Platform Matters?
Live, user managed information
Less third party control
Collaboration without barriers
Bridging informal & formal
Scan the QR, Select your Profile, Start connecting!
Hosted by,
#CreativeDignity

A recurring concern was the sector’s culture of secrecy, which often hides artisans and enables imitation products. The newly launched **handmade.world** platform, initiated by Creative Dignity, aims to address this by making artisans visible, verified, and connected through an open, multilingual, and collaborative digital network.



Panel 3: Crafts and Climate Change: Mitigation and Resilience Building





Panel 3 opened up a thoughtful conversation on how crafts fit into the larger climate change and sustainability discourse. While climate action is usually discussed in terms of industry and policy, the panel highlighted that crafts already embody many **sustainable principles** — they are typically low-carbon, resource-efficient, and socially inclusive. As the sector grows, especially in export markets, aligning with global sustainability norms will become increasingly important.

The discussion suggested that crafts could become powerful storytellers for sustainability. Handmade products, particularly those purchased by high-income consumers who contribute more to global emissions, can communicate deeper messages about **responsible consumption**.



Solar powered silk reeling

The panel also emphasized that sustainability in crafts goes far beyond carbon. It includes raw material sourcing, water and energy use, biodiversity, waste, community impact, and circularity. Technology and innovation — such as cleaner fuels and improved production processes — can further support artisans while reducing health risks.



The way forward calls for **better documentation, shared sustainability language, and collaborative initiatives** that position crafts as advocates for planetary well-being.




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Sources

Crafts Council of India

Creative Dignity

https://dialogue.earth/en/energy/solar-powered-looms-boost-income-and-safety-for-indias-silk-weavers/